My Monday Morning: Ludwig Göransson

Podcast: Wall street journal

AI Executive Summary

1. Core Thesis Ludwig Jornsson, a multi-award-winning composer, outlines his philosophy that sustainable success requires a disciplined morning routine balanced with deep, reflective contemplation of one's impact. The episode emphasizes how creative freedom is best achieved when directors and collaborators understand the process intimately, allowing for experimentation before production begins. Furthermore, it highlights the necessity of intentional post-project reflection to manage burnout ("diving") and maintain personal well-being alongside professional output, all illustrated through his recent work recreating ancient instruments for Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*.

2. Key Arguments & Data * **Morning Routine:** During final project phases (e.g., 3 months pre-release), Jornsson wakes at approximately 5:40 AM to hike in Griffith Park (4–5 minutes) with his dog Barbara; during lighter times, he wakes later but maintains this early ritual. He prefers black coffee and steel-cut oatmeal for breakfast (spiced with cinnamon/cardamom) over traditional Fika snacks due to a Swedish upbringing where 2 breaks/day are mandatory at work. * **Career Metrics:** At 42 years old, his portfolio includes 3 Oscars, Grammys, Golden Globes, and Emmys. His awards are currently stored on the bottom shelf of a bookshelf in his studio. He is working to complete a solo record project that has been in progress for 8 years prior to undertaking new film commissions. * **Directorial Collaboration:** Both Christopher Nolan and Ryan Coogler demonstrate an "immense understanding" of Jornsson's process, often knowing exactly what didn't work or needs changing. This familiarity allows them to give him the freedom to experiment early in the script phase rather than being constrained by tight production schedules. * **Ancient Instrument Research (*The Odyssey*):** The project required recreating Bronze Age instruments (Aulos and Lyre). Jornsson collaborated with musicians Rosa Fragruti (Lyre specialist) and Callum Von Strong (Aulos specialist) to build replicas from museum studies. Key technical challenge involves playing double reed pipes simultaneously to generate overtones for a dynamic sound range unique to the 4,000-year-old instrument. * **Creative Reflection:** Jornsson uses the metaphor of being "a diver" regarding intense

creative projects. After a project ends, he must take time to "compress" his experience to contemplate the impact on his life, family, and self before starting new work.

3. Actionable Takeaways * Establish Consistent Mornings: Regardless of workload intensity, implement an early morning structure that includes physical movement (hiking/walking), nature engagement, and a specific dietary routine (oatmeal/coffee) to anchor the day. * **Seek Process-Aligned Partners:** When collaborating on creative projects (music or otherwise), select directors or producers who understand your workflow deeply. Their ability to trust your decisions allows for early-stage experimentation, which yields higher creativity than working within rigid constraints. * **Intentionally Reflect:** After completing major work, do not immediately jump into the next project. Dedicate time to "compress" your experience and journal/contemplate the effects of your work on relationships and personal growth. * **Balance Work and Personal Goals:** Before accepting new film commitments, ensure there is space for unfinished personal creative goals (e.g., finishing a solo record) to maintain equilibrium between professional success and personal happiness.

Full Transcript

I'm Ludwig Jornsson, and this is my Monday morning. Ludwig Jornsson is one of the most successful music composers in the world. He's composed for TV shows like Community and New Girl, Produced for Adele and Alicia Keys, and scored blockbuster films for Ryan Coogler and Christopher Nolan, which landed him three Oscars. He also has a number of Grammys, Golden Globes, and Emmys, and he's only 42.

His latest project is Nolan's The Odyssey, and for it, Ludwig went looking for instruments most people haven't heard for thousands of years. For his Monday morning, Ludwig told me about Predon Hikes' past coyotes in Griffith Park, why Swedes are entitled to daily cinnamon buns, and how he professionally collaborates with his wife, Serena. I'm Lane Fleursheim, and that's coming up after the break. Are you looking for a trusted health insurance? Allianz covers you beyond borders. We deliver peace of mind just a click away with global telehealth access and round-the-clock support. Backed by 2 million healthcare providers worldwide, we're trusted as the number one insurance brand for the last seven years. Visit AllianzCare.com and explore our Singapore plans to find out more. Terms and conditions apply. This is a show where we get into morning routines. So what time do you usually wake up on a Monday and what's the first thing you do after waking up?

So it depends on kind of where I'm at in my work if it's like one of the craziest times or if it's one of the lesser crazier times because when I'm During a final time of a project, you know two three months before the movie comes out I'm like, you know work very late and stuff But if not, I try to get up early in the morning get up like I've actually gotten a really great routine lately where I get up at around 540 and I do a little hike around Griffith Park with my dog Barbara And it's bad. It's crazy because now it's so dark in the morning So it's so you know I almost need to have a flashlight on or something because there's a bunch of coyotes and stuff in the park But um, it's um, that's that so I do like a four to five minute hike Eraman Griffith Park, go around the Greek theater, and then, you know, it's like so beautiful over there. And then I come home, make some coffee. I

wake the kids up. And we actually have, we started getting the newspaper. So that's like a nice thing. Like right before you get into the front door, you just pick up the newspaper, put it on the table. It feels like such an adult, an accomplished adult.

So that's been great. And then at 7.30, we're off to drive to school. That sounds like a really nice morning minus perhaps the potential coyote sightings. How do you take your coffee and do you eat breakfast in the morning? Yeah, I do coffee just black. You know, I mean, growing up in Sweden, you kind of, you start, everyone start drinking coffee very early, you know, in age, because that's kind of how you survived the long winters. And also in Sweden there's something called Fika. Fika means it's a word for taking a break and drinking coffee and eat buns, cinnamon buns. At every workplace you have to have at least two Fikas in the day. So it's kind of ingrained in the system, kind of drinking a lot of coffee and I don't get too affected by it either. So I can kind of have it pretty late in the day too. So I can have, you know, one at six, one at eight, one at ten.

And then that too, maybe. Well, I was going to ask if you take feces during your work day here too. I do, but the cinnamon bun has been, you know, there's some great places in LA now where you can get the Swedish cinnamon buns. But I don't have it for breakfast. Normally for breakfast, I usually, I'd really do the oatmeal. It's like steel cut oatmeal. And then usually also the tip is a trick is that you can put some banana in it. while you're boiling it. So that makes it a little sweeter. And I also put the cinnamon and cardamom in the steel cut oatmeal. So it feels a little Christmasy when you eat it. What's the first thing that you intentionally listen to on most days? Like a sound part of your mornings at all? Yeah, I mean, it depends. Again, if I'm working, it's a great time to listen to the demos to where I'm at in the process.

you know, to what I created in the studio the day before, how it sounds like. So that's a great time to listen to demos. Also, I love, you know, new music Friday. Or, you know, that's when you can listen to the new songs and new albums trying to stay up to date with the current music. And then also, and sometimes a lot lately, I've been listening to a lot of podcasts. So I started listening to some Swedish podcasts, which been great actually. It really

enjoy it. In general, what draws you to the work of scoring a movie? What are like the most challenging and rewarding parts about collaborating with people kind of across art forms like that? I mean, I love learning things. I love when you're... And that's so great with the films I'm able to work on, like nothing is the same.

Every move is completely different. I feel like I'm very blessed in terms of every artist and director I get to work with are so creative and trying to push the world of music and cinema and experiences forward. Also being giving the freedom to experiment and the time to experiment because normally A lot of times when you work on a film or TV, the schedule is so congested. You're like, oh, you have two months to finish this. And if there's no time, there's no time for trial and error. And working with great authors like Nolan and Kugler, they're also writing their film. So I get to be involved at a very, very early stage of the process when I have a script.

And they haven't even shot the film yet. So when they're shooting the film, I can just be traveling around and experiment and do things that I don't think is going to work and then end up working. And that's really where I can feel like I can be the most creative when I'm not locked in front of a screen, in front of a MIDI keyboard in my studio, which is also a huge part of the process. But that's in a way, I don't feel as... as creative as I do when I'm just completely free. Yeah. Well, you have these ongoing collaborations with both Christopher Nolan and Ryan Coogler. What is it like working with each of them process-wise? Like, how are they different from each other? I mean, one thing that they're very similar to each other is that I feel like they know everything. I feel like they know in terms of everything that I'm doing. Like, if I didn't work Tuesday night, or choose a morning deal, like they know exactly whatever that didn't work. Or if I'm working on a certain section of a movie, I don't know, it's like they both have an immense understanding of my process. And I think that's really important when you're working with some creative and they really are involved in my process.

available anytime for a question or can talk about music in a you know very break it down in a very Real way like to point out the instruments point out, you know the feelings talk about music in with in musical terms, you know

So that's very similar and and then what's different about them, you know, it's it's Everyone has a different process but for me like that's a great because, you know, not doing the same thing over and over again is, I think, very helpful. Coming up, Ludwig gets into his musical journey scoring the Odyssey. Are you looking for a trusted health insurance? Allianz covers you beyond borders. We deliver peace of mind just a click away with global telehealth access and round-the-clock support. Backed by 2 million healthcare providers worldwide, we're trusted as the number one insurance brand for the last seven years.

Visit AllianzCare.com and explore our Singapore plans to find out more. Terms and conditions apply. Your most recent project, of course, was the Odyssey. And for it, you and your team recreated ancient instruments. Can you tell me about some of them and the research that went into making and using them? Yeah, I would say it was one of the things that Chris Nolan was very interested in. What we know from that area, the bronze age is very limited but there's some paintings of these ancient instruments like the Aulus and also in the actual Odyssey, the lyre is part of the Odyssey as well. The pluck of the bow sounds like the pluck of the lyre. And so we just needed to find people in the world that can still play those instruments. And there's, you know, maybe not that many in America. So, so what I did was, was going to Europe and I found some like specialists, you know, working with Rosa Fragrupti on an incredible Lyre player and Callum Von Strong, an incredible Aulis player. And these are, you know, instruments that I never worked with before. And also, I think what's so interesting about these instruments is that they're so unique.

So I had written music for the film. I had early demos for the film. So I knew what the themes were and I knew what the chords were. But I needed to sit down with the musicians and they're also researchers. And I need to sit down and see, listen to how they're using their instruments and really understand what it is that makes this instrument unique. And then I can infuse... the music that I've written for the film into those instruments. Once I learn how to best optimize what makes them unique. How do you write music for an instrument like the Alos that... Well, I thought it hadn't been used in over a thousand years, but I guess you found someone who plays it. But, you know, what are the challenges of that process? Yeah, I mean, not

only does Colin play it, but he also makes it together with his companion Max.

they have to recreate the instrument. And his friend is an incredible woodworker, so they actually make the instrument from replicas from what they've seen in museums. And also they have to make the reeds as well. So these are basically two flutes to do double reed pipes that you play at the same time. And what's unique about this is that When you play them at the same time, the two notes create these overtones. The air that comes out creates these overtones. So you get an incredible dynamic range of sounds. And you can play it super soft and you can play it super loud. And the shift in tone is so interesting. And it makes sense that this was the most popular instrument, you know, 4,000 years ago. It was like the most popular instrument for about 2,000 years in the ancient world up until I think 300 BC when Christianity became very popular. And they said the instrument was too pagan.

I heard an interview where you talked about how as you've got an older, you've realized the importance of reflecting after a project and thinking about the impact it had on you. And I was wondering what that looks like for you. Are you journaling and writing things down or are you just kind of taking time to contemplate or? I'm definitely taking time to contemplate. I think that's a very important part of it. And sometimes you just forced into getting straight jumping straight into something new Which is tough but having some time afterwards to contemplate What you did what you went through your experience Because it's not just it's not just music like you have to like also understand what it did to your life You're like what it like what effect did it have on me? You know on on you know my relationships, what effect that I have on my family, what effect, like how did I change as a person while working on this and the person I am afterwards. Because I do, I do like to, you know, when I do really like to dive into the, the products that I'm working on, like very, very, you know, heavily. So like, if I'm into something, I'm into it for, you know, a hundred.

10%, you know? And so you get into it so hard. So when you get out of it, you need some time to kind of compress what you call like a diver. And when you're down as a diver, you have to compress before you go up. Have

you had time to have those kind of reflections for the Odyssey and think about what impact it had on you? Yeah, I feel like I'm going through it right now. like right now is we're talking. So yeah, I think it's been and I do feel like kind of what I was saying in the beginning of our conversation was like, I love going into every projects with the curiosity of like learning something new. And I feel very so happy and lucky that I'm able to learn a lot of like meeting People from completely different cultures or the plate completely different music and and So at this time, you know, this the yeah, I'm I'm Having some time to reflect about kind of what we did and and and how Fun it actually, you know, it was so much fun. What's one of your most fun memories? I think it was just the places I got to go to The first time I started writing for the Odyssey was actually in LA in January during the crazy fires. Oh, wow fires I remember Serena and the kids they went up, you know, up north their parents and like so where I was staying there was a it was it was about to vacate but we didn't have to but but I was in the studio and we I rented about like 40 40 bronze gongs so and I had a week in the studio and so It was a time where it was like ghostly quiet, you know, but I was in there trying to make songs, compositions, just by playing these huge gongs and figuring out how I can come up with a system where I can just make songs with just gongs. So that's where the journey started. And then a couple of months later, I was in Italy in Lippery. They were all there on set shooting the sirens.

shooting the sirens again and I got to go on the boat and you know just just just step in that world for a little bit before I went on to my next adventure was which was going back to LA in the studio right 10 more days in a studio and in my studio write more songs and then after that I went to Southern Albania recorded with some incredible musicians there so I got to I got to just travel a lot a lot of incredible people. It sounds like you went on your very own journey through that process. This is kind of a silly question, but where do you keep your awards? Right now, they're in the studio, which is about 10 minutes from the house. And it's on the bottom shelf. And I have this bookshelf behind my couch. And that's where the awards are right now. And I think I'll keep them there.

You've talked about being someone who always has a five or a 10-year plan. What are some of your current goals? Do you have a dream project

you haven't worked on yet? Yeah, I mean, right now my goal is to... I do want to finish my record, which has been sitting on in the back of my mind since almost eight years ago I started it. So that's my goal now before I start my next movie project. to finish my own record. And, you know, just, we always, I think we're always looking for the perfect balance. So I feel like every year I'm getting closer to that, you know? And also just thinking about kind of like, you know, what makes you happy in life except from work, you know? You know, I know that work makes me really happy and playing music, but finding those things, you know?

Outside of that that also makes me happy It's something that I'm working on too and sometimes in this series I like to ask people what the secret to a happy marriage or relationship is and I know that you and your wife Serena who's a violinist and producer also frequently collaborate together So I wanted to ask you what's the secret to working together so well. I mean first of all it comes down to you know respect, you know and and we have a mutual respect for each other in terms of human beings, but also as musicians. And I really trust her opinions as a musician and what her case is as a musician. And I think that's a huge part of it. Whatever she has to say of the music that we're working on is always extremely important. And she's also able to hear things that I'm not.

And, you know, together we're able to, you know, take it to the next level and bring it further. And, you know, yeah, just being able to do that with your partners is, I think, incredible. Well, it was so much fun talking to you for this. Thank you so much for joining my Monday morning and, you know, telling us about your mornings and your work. Thank you, Elaine. It was great to be here and great talking to you. My Monday Morning is part of The Journal, which is a co-production of Spotify Studios and The Wall Street Journal. I'm Lane Fleursheim, and we'll be back with another episode of My Monday Morning next week. Follow us on Spotify or wherever you get your podcasts. And follow me on Instagram, at Lane Fleursheim, for more behind-the-scenes stuff from My Monday Morning, and to let me know what you think of the show. This episode was produced by Juvica Verma with help from Pia Gadkari, edited by Catherine Brewer and Sarah Platt.

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